

Carol Bales

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UX RESEARCH LEADER

UX Research leader specializing in supporting mission-driven organizations navigate periods of rapid growth or change — establishing research structure, strengthening cross-functional alignment, and delivering high-impact insights that help teams adapt quickly to evolving market conditions. Worked with IBM, Coca-Cola, Delta Airlines, IHG, TWC, Fiserv and more.

CORE COMPETENCIES

UX Leadership in Complex, Cross-Functional Environments
Building Research Maturity and Insight Infrastructure
Aligning Stakeholders Around User-Centered Outcomes

Research Strategy for Scaling Organizations
Rapid Insight Generation for Strategic Decision-Making
Turning Complex Signals into Actionable Product Strategy

WORK EXPERIENCE

SILVER SPRING INTERACTIVE, Atlanta, GA

Jan 2024 – present

Principal UX Strategist & Researcher

Provide strategic UX research and usability engineering for mission-driven organizations and emerging ventures navigating digital transformation and complex user needs.

- Conducted heuristic evaluation and strategic UX recommendations for WABE 90.1 FM Digital Services, improving readability and user experience as the organization expanded toward digital-first audience engagement.
- Designed and developed a well-being and clarity-focused application, translating research insights into functional prototypes that explore structured decision support and user-centered scaffolding.

THE WEATHER CHANNEL (THE WEATHER COMPANY, IBM) Atlanta, GA

Oct 2018 – Aug 2023

Sr. User Researcher, Sr. Manager Consumer Insights

Led UX research strategy for a complex, multi-platform ecosystem serving 400M+ users across three brands. Built research maturity and cross-functional alignment during a period of rapid growth, enabling teams to translate complex user signals into actionable product and business strategy.

Driving product strategy through research

- Led mixed-methods research initiatives connecting weather experiences to emotional and physical well-being; insights informed major app redesign and integrated marketing strategy.
- B2B usability research marking safety thresholds for adding weather information to in-vehicle infotainment and navigation systems.
- Established quarterly UX metrics program, identifying a 7% YoY decline in perceived usability tied to ad density, balancing revenue priorities with long-term product health.
- Partnered with Product, Design, Editorial, Marketing, Analytics, and Advertising teams to embed insight-driven decision-making across the organization.

Supporting growth, retention, and subscription strategy

- Synthesized acquisition and churn research into customer journey frameworks, highlighting competitive behaviors and informing first-time user experience improvements.
- Evaluated editorial and subscription feature concepts using prioritization and iterative testing, leading to successful product releases.
- Improved subscription purchase flow efficiency by 37% through iterative user research.
- Contributed to a 26% increase in NPS for a major newsletter through ongoing metrics and experience research.

Building scalable research infrastructure

- Built and led a high-velocity research practice delivering rapid insights across multiple product teams.
- Launched centralized research repository and recurring research showcases, increasing transparency, stakeholder alignment, and organizational adoption of user-centered practices.
- Developed standards, mentoring programs, and flexible team frameworks that supported sustainable performance during high-demand periods, including Covid.
- Elevated UX practice maturity by introducing shared research language and frameworks that strengthened product strategy conversations and decision-making.

SILVER SPRING INTERACTIVE, Atlanta, GA

Feb 2011 – Sep 2018

UX Designer, Strategist and Researcher

Partnered with mission-driven and enterprise organizations across transportation, government, finance, and startups to navigate complex product and organizational challenges. Delivered UX strategy, research, and design leadership that translated ambiguous business goals into structured product direction and actionable design frameworks.

- Led UX design engagements to improve consumer- and employee-facing systems during periods of growth and increasing complexity.
- Reduced call wait and processing times for Delta Airlines' legacy call-center platform by identifying workflow inefficiencies and implementing usability best practices.
- UX design of Web and mobile management of reloadable Visa cards for InComm.
- UX strategy for Y Combinator startup Exception-ALLY, to clarify product direction and user value during early-stage growth.
- Improved satisfaction and reduced attrition within Brookdale Senior Living's community selection and move-in process through research-driven service design.

FISERV, Atlanta, GA

May 2009 – Jan 2011

Sr. UX Architect (& Researcher)

Led UX strategy and research for complex financial systems supporting bill-pay users and internal call-center operations. Partnered closely with product, engineering, and business stakeholders to clarify requirements and improve usability across high-volume transactional platforms.

- Improved findability of critical information by 70% within a complex bill-pay call-center application, reducing cognitive load and improving operational efficiency.
- Enhanced search performance and usability for Walmart Money Centers through redesign of Fiserv's biller search API workflows.
- Introduced iterative prototyping and user testing practices to align cross-functional teams around user needs and reduce development risk.
- Translated complex financial workflows into intuitive user experiences, improving alignment between business goals and user outcomes.

CARTOON NETWORK, Atlanta, GA

July 2008 – Jan 2009

UX Architect

As part of the FusionFall team, I worked closely with product management and game designers to prototype and document UX design features both online and in-game.

- Created efficient Web account sign-up and account management
- Improved usability for in-game heads-up-display for MMOG FusionFall

INTERCONTINENTAL HOTELS GROUP, Atlanta, GA

Mar 2004 – Sep 2005

UX Architect

Led UX strategy and design for complex global reservation platforms supporting multiple brands, languages, and international markets. Helped improve conversion and operational clarity by translating complex booking workflows into intuitive user experiences.

- Refined end-to-end hotel search and reservation flows through iterative wireframing, prototyping, usability testing, and A/B experimentation.
- Collaborated with internal teams and external vendors to establish user-centered decision frameworks for optimizing reservation completion.
- Improved efficiency across search results, hotel detail, and booking flows, creating measurable revenue gains across international sites.
- Supported large-scale content management ecosystem spanning multiple brands and localized experiences.

IBM INTERACTIVE DESIGN STUDIOS, Atlanta, GA

Mar 1999 – July 2003

Sr. Information Architect

UX strategy and design on enterprise digital transformation initiatives across finance, transportation, publishing, and entertainment sectors. Partnered with cross-functional teams to translate evolving business strategies and technological shifts into structured information architecture and interaction design.

- Interaction design and documentation for complex enterprise platforms and emerging digital experiences.
- Conducted strategic UX consulting including heuristic evaluations, process assessments, content strategy, and information visualization.
- Supported proposal and delivery teams in shaping scalable experience solutions aligned with organizational and technological change.
- Helped organizations navigate shifts in business process and technology by creating structured experience models that clarified user and stakeholder needs.

ACADEMIA

GEORGIA STATE UNIVERSITY, Atlanta, GA

Jan 2018 – Apr 2025

Part-time Instructor, Dept of Computer Science

Teaching Intro to Human-Computer Interaction: Teams use human-centered research and design practices to prototype a solution to a real human problem then research their prototype. Preparing students for lifelong problem-solving using recent product design processes.

EDUCATION

Master of Computer Science, Human-Computer Interaction

Georgia Institute of Technology, Atlanta, GA

Bachelor of Arts, Fine Arts

University of Tennessee, Knoxville, TN

PUBLICATIONS

McKillop MM, VanHouten C, Bales C, Felix W, Hekmat R, Purcell Jackson G. Assessing and addressing COVID-19 information needs via a weather application. JAMIA Open. 2022;5(1):00ac016. Published 2022 Mar 26. doi:10.1093/jamiaopen/00ac016

Bales, C., Do, Ellen Yi-Luen. Managing information in a creative environment. In Proceedings of the seventh ACM conference on Creativity and cognition (C&C '09). Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 353-354. <https://doi.org/10.1145/1640233.1640297>

CERTIFICATIONS

- Enterprise Designing Thinking Practitioner. IBM. Aug, 2019
- IBM Agile Explorer. IBM. Aug 2019

SKILLS & TOOLS

Skills (Research): User Research, Heuristic Evaluation, Usability, Qualitative/Quantitative, Research Design, Remote-moderated or unmoderated, Mixed methods, Formative & Summative, Research-based Requirements-writing, Moderation, SUS, NPS, CSAT, RITE Method, Surveys, Third-party data, Usage metrics, GenAI for Research

Skills (Strategy & Other): UX Strategy, UX Design, UI Design, Design Thinking, Interaction Design, Prototyping, Journey Mapping, Innovation, Excellent Communications & Storytelling, Emerging Tech, Vibe Coding

Skills (Leadership): People Manager, Practice Building, Team Leader, Mentoring & Coaching, Budget & Planning, Teaching, Vendor Management, Stakeholder Relations

Industries: Media, Financial, Transportation, Hospitality, Government, Entertainment, Gaming, eCommerce, Telecomm, SaaS, InfoTech, Privacy Compliance

Tools: Alchemer, UserZoom, SPSS, Mural, UserTesting, Qualtrics, Morai, OvoStudios, Figma, Mural, InDesign, Axure, Adobe XD, Adobe Photoshop, ChatGPT, Gemini, Midjourney, Trello, Slack, Jira, Salesforce, OneTrust, Discourse, Generative AI, Visual Studio Code